

Samsung Digimax 350SE

Made for the mob

The 350SE sports the best build quality of all the cameras we tested, with a solid rugged body shell that can take a beating. Four AA batteries power the camera. The 240 gms weight has its own advantages and disadvantages—it makes it stable when shooting, but cumbersome on a trip. There were just two disadvantages we faced—one that the lens takes an unusually long time to extend, and the second being the five-way menu navigation switch, which is ultra smooth and doesn't feel tactile.

The Digimax 350SE has a 3.2 megapixel CCD sensor, coupled with a 3X optical zoom lens and 2X digital zoom. It supports ISO speed, ranging from 100 to 400, which is useful when taking pictures in poor light, to increase the CCD sensitivity. The shutter speed ranges from 4 seconds to 1/2000th of a second—again a boon, since you can use it in any lighting conditions. Similarly, it has five flash modes for different lighting conditions.

It did not reproduce the test image as crisply as it should have—the quality of the colours deviated as much as 25 per cent, so did the luminance. Specular effects and gradation shading effects were also affected by the low brightness. Surprisingly, in the zoom test, the photograph was quite vibrant, indicating that it requires a good amount of light.

Priced at Rs 24,995, the 350SE seems a bit expensive with many other cameras retailing for around the same price, but giving much better results.

"Is just the right camera for the serious, but very, very low budget tourist. Good image quality, but isn't very quick in the aim-and-shoot category. Also, it is just a little expensive for the price. Samsung should sell it at about 21,000, if it plans to eat into the established digicam companies whose products are far superior."

—Sherwin Crasto

- + Very good zoom quality
- Bulky, mediocre performance

Price: Rs 24,995

Samsung Digimax 350SE C	
Performance	▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶
Features	▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶
Ergonomics	▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶
Value for money	▶ ▶ ▶ ▶ ▶



Expert Opinion Sherwin Crasto

Mr Sherwin Crasto, who is currently working with Reuters as a senior news photographer, has been using a professional digital camera right from the time they were introduced. Sherwin has been a photographer since 1983, and has been associated with many newspapers—The Indian Post and with Associated Press for the South Asian region, to name a few, working mostly as a senior photographer. He was also the chief photographer for The Independent.

In the year 2000, he received specialised training in war coverage, handling hostile environments, driving skills and first aid at Heckfield, England. Recently, he had a close shave while covering the Afghanistan war, when an Afghan rebel opened fire on his car. He has also spent a day on the American aircraft carrier, Carl Vinson, from which American fighter planes took off to bomb key Al Qaeda locations. He covered the hijacking episode of the Indian Airlines plane at Kandahar. During the Kargil war, he jumped to save himself from an oncoming mortar and in the process broke his digital camera.

The mid-air collision between a Saudia Boeing and a Khazakhstan plane at Charki Dadri near Delhi, Pope John Paul II's visit to India and Sri Lanka, former US president, Bill Clinton's visit to India, the last solar eclipse of the millennium at the Rann of Kutch, are some examples of his long list of prestigious assignments.

In the year 2001, Sherwin was awarded the Commonwealth Photographic Award on Environment for his picture on the burning of a tiger pelt seized from poachers.

He was also the Photo-Journalist of the year 1997-98, an award given by the Mahanagar Newspaper.



PHOTOGRAPH: Jiten Gandhi

Capturing Images Outdoors

Digital cameras are great for shooting outdoors. Since this will involve capturing moving objects on film, a few things need to be attended to.

The first, and foremost is the shutter speed. Most digital cameras have a shutter speed ranging from 1 second to 1/500th of a second. You can set the shutter speed to its slowest while capturing the sunset to allow maximum amount of light to enter, thereby yielding a vibrant and lively image.

The shutter speed should be as high as around 1/200th of a second, when capturing fast moving objects, such as a speeding car.

Digital cameras also offer white balance settings such as incandescent, tungsten, sunlight, etc. Use these settings to improve the image quality, and make it look as close to reality as possible. You can either select pre-defined settings, depending upon the backdrop, or set them manually.